

Warabiya

Fishing Through the Storm

I used to see the kids every day, running, biking, fishing rods over their shoulders, rushing out after school, always heading somewhere different. I kept wondering how news of the *good* fishing spots traveled so fast between them. Some kind of island-grade, low-tech, child-powered communication network.

One afternoon, they gathered at the port. It happened to be my day off. So I jumped on my tiny pink, aggressively *kawaii* folding bike, grabbed my rod, and rode back to join them, pretending this was all very casual.

They were shy at first. Quick smiles, eyes darting back to their lines. A few were fooling around, but most were intensely focused, serious in that way only kids can be when something actually matters.

Then Yuma showed up. He's Rai-san's son. We'd already bonded over Beyblades and Pokémon at Sunny Coral, which, as far as friendships go, is a solid foundation. He walked straight up to me and explained, very carefully, how pier fishing actually works. I'd mostly fished rivers back in Spain. This was a different world.

He asked me my favorite Pokémon. I wanted to say *Scyther*, but didn't know the Japanese name, so I told a small, strategic lie.

"Lizardon ga suki desu."

Charizard.

He nodded vigorously. Approval granted. Then, realizing I could understand *some* Japanese, as kids and elderly people love to do, he immediately switched to full-speed mode. A verbal flamethrower. I nodded back, just as vigorously, hoping enthusiasm could replace comprehension.

Rain started as a drizzle. No one moved. Then it turned into real rain. Still, no one moved. Finally, it became proper Okinawan rain, horizontal, loud, soaking, disrespectful.

Even with my Gore-Tex jacket, I was drenched, so I just gave up to the rain. Some mums came to retrieve their kids. I waved goodbye to Yuma. A small group remained, completely unbothered, rods still in the water.

That's when Akiko-san appeared, carrying umbrellas. Not to stop them, she clearly knew better, but to make the situation survivable. She smiled at me, tall and calm, the kind of presence that makes chaos feel organized. In flawless English, she joked that I was a very motivated fisherman.

We talked in the rain. I explained I was helping at the guesthouse. She told me the kids weren't hers, they lived at her place, Warabiya, a kind of boarding home for children from all over Japan. Tokyo, Osaka. Parents sending them here to grow up close to the sea and forest, learning by doing. I thought back to the Protestant boarding school in Fribourg I had narrowly escaped as a kid. Same concept. Very different execution.

That's when the sign I'd seen near my house finally made sense (□□□□).

After half an hour of rain-soaked conversation, we headed home. It was my first day with the Warabiya kids. Definitely not the last.

Jam and Other Escalations

Some days they came back carrying stories. Other days, proof. Once, it was a dead *habu* snake, limp and heavy, held up like a trophy by hands still small enough to belong in classrooms. Another time, a massive moray eel, its body coiled in a

bucket, teeth still looking offended. Through it all, the same thing never changed, their smiles. Calm, proud, completely unshaken, as if this was simply what afternoons were for.

That's also how I learned Akiko-san kept chickens. Not as a hobby, but as part of the rhythm of the place. She sold eggs when she had enough, nothing more, nothing less. The eggs were incredible, deep yellow, rich, the kind that remind you food has a past before the pan. That's also when I met her own daughters Renka and Hanaka, moving through the house with easy confidence, helping without being asked. Everyone seemed oddly competent here, not in a showy way, but in that quiet, reassuring manner that makes you realize you're the least prepared person in the room, and somehow, that's okay.

After a long trek, I crossed to the neighboring island and found perfectly ripe adan fruits, heavy, geometric clusters growing straight out of a tree that looks half-designed by nature, half by stubbornness. The adan (*Pandanus tectorius*), sometimes called screw pine, is everywhere in Okinawa: along beaches, at the edge of forests, standing firm against salt, wind, and especially ... typhoons. Its fruit looks more like an artifact than something edible, a mosaic of hard, angular segments, bright orange when ripe, stubbornly resistant to the idea of being food, like a Devil Fruit pulled straight out of *One Piece*, mysterious, powerful-looking, and clearly not meant to be eaten without consequences.. In brief, I obviously needed it ! You wouldn't guess it at first glance, but with time, heat, and patience, it slowly gives in, releasing a dense, fibrous flesh with a flavor somewhere between pineapple and overripe mango, the kind of taste that feels ancient, as if it fed people long before anyone thought of supermarkets. Since I had way too much, and baking cookies with only a Japanese fish grill is an act of pure faith, I brought some to my neighbors.

They were impressed. Curious. *Oishii desu ka?*.. It was apparently.

That evening, Akiko-san invited me in. I hesitated, Japan teaches you to refuse three times, but eventually accepted. The kids had caught a couple of *katsuo* (bonito fish). One was cleaning it, another slicing *sashimi*, another skewering for *tataki*. Vegetables grilled over a *shichirin* (Japanese bbq grill). As the smoke curled upward, their young voices intertwined, singing *Seikai* by the RADWIMPS. The melody filled the air. This song, that every child in Japan knows by heart, is a poignant coming-of-age anthem about leaving behind the neat, multiple-choice questions of school to face the wild, unpredictable realities of adulthood. Watching them expertly carve the fish and tend the fire while singing about finding their own answers in life, it felt as though I was witnessing that very transition take shape right before my eyes.

Calm, coordinated chaos, conducted gently by Akiko-san. Watching them move around the house, it slowly sank in how self-sufficient they were. Not pushed, not supervised every second, just quietly encouraged to figure things out on their own. They learned by doing, by failing, adjusting, trying again, and it showed in the way they handled knives, food, animals, even each other. There was a kind of calm self-assurance in them that felt rare, something I'd never really seen in kids that age, and it made me wonder how different growing up could feel when trust comes before control.

A young guy with long, tied-back hair came over and introduced himself with a small bow, offered me a beer. Keita-san, a staff helper, gentle and reserved, already dreaming aloud about building a place like this one someday.

The food was incredible. Sesame oil in soy sauce with *sashimi*, chef's kiss! Shintaro, one of the oldest kids explained song lyrics to me. I introduced him to *Def Tech*. We discussed what a "yankee" was. Cultural exchange complete.

As the night wound down, Akiko-san approached me.

"Can I ask you a favor?"

"Mochiron." (Of course)

She smiled and walked away.

I had no idea what I'd just agreed to...

The Boar

A hunter had caught a wild boar in Aharen. Invasive species. They were bringing it over. They needed help butchering it.

I was not ready for that sentence..

Still, we prepared. I sharpened knives. Plastic sheets went down. Keita put the kids to bed.

Then Reiji, Akiko-san's husband, arrived in a kei-truck that looked seconds away from tipping over from the weight.

The boar was enormous. Tusks. Head like a battering ram. We lifted it together, tied the legs, and Reiji worked quickly and precisely. Calm. Focused. Blood everywhere. No hesitation, he moved with a calm precision I'd only ever seen in a Japanese person.

We skinned it. Renka, the older daughter worked beside me, confidently, skillfully. No ceremony. Just work.

By nine pm we were deep into it, I was in charge of holding the beast while the others were cutting it into chunks and bagging them.

Reiji was completely focused, unfazed by the blood splashing across his glasses or by the raw, overpowering smell of the insides, a smell I was doing my best to endure without showing it. The stench was intense, almost unreal, but I was holding myself together.

At one point, he simply handed me the knife and said, "Now you do." I froze, stiff as a stone. Then I gathered what courage I had left, grabbed the leg, studied the joints, and went at it. I couldn't stop thinking about the *jamón serrano* I grew up with in Spain, a whole pig leg hanging quietly in the back of the kitchen. This was that memory stripped of all distance, the real thing.

It made me realize how much we separate animals from food, how far we've distanced ourselves from the process itself. But these people, these kids, hadn't. They knew exactly what it meant. They didn't flinch, and because of that, they seemed to respect the animal even more. Not a single piece was left on the bone; everything that could be eaten was used.

We eventually wrapped it up with Reiji. An *otsukaresama desu* (thank you for your hard work) and he was already gone, off to clean the blood from the boar's head.

I went back inside. After asking how it had been, Akiko-san handed me a small plastic bag of meat as a token appreciation. I thanked them for hosting me, and for letting me be part of it, and then headed home. It was half past midnight. The moon was almost full, bright enough to follow me the whole way.

When I entered the guesthouse, I startled a few guests who were still hanging out in the kitchen having beers. Understandably so, a man covered in blood, carrying a suspicious bag, isn't exactly reassuring. I didn't have the energy to explain. I just shrugged, put the meat in the freezer, and headed for the shower.

I watched the blood mix with the water, spreading and thinning like ink. I thought about all those crime shows where murderers stare at the spiral of the sink as the last traces disappear. Strangely, it was beautiful. Hypnotic, even...